

"He That Keepeth Understanding Shall Find Good"

On Moral-Existential Considerations in Cognitive Judgments

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A. Introduction

Many veils hide from us the true nature of reality. We strive to attain a true and precise grasp of things as they are, but this striving always remains a request that is never fully granted. We see objects; we experience the world through our five senses; we analyze the data we receive analytically and develop rational conclusions from it; and still the world that surrounds us remains shrouded in fog, with far more of the mysterious and the merely presumed in it than of the truly known.

Although, from a purely logical standpoint, we are able to cast doubt on almost the entire breadth of our experience and our assumptions, in simple, everyday existential experience we encounter real uncertainty in only a small, relative portion of the surfaces of our lives. We do not know our future, which is subject to factors impossible to foresee. We do not know what is in the hearts of our acquaintances, what the other wants or thinks or intends to do. We struggle with philosophical and metaphysical questions concerned with gauging and defining the inner nature of the world and of man. We do not know how to assess the spiritual dimension of reality, such as the worth of a person in the eyes of God, or how to decipher the providential meaning of historical events, past and present. How do we deal with these hazy areas? How do we cope with a lack of knowledge, how do we fill in the missing data?

This essay will deal with the process of "completing" knowledge. In many places, although, rationally speaking, the paths to correct and well-founded knowledge are seemingly undermined, we "complete" gaps by means and methods of lower epistemological value than the rest of the knowledge we hold in our lives, and yet the hypotheses or "knowledge" we adopt become an important part of our "array of knowledge" — the one that leads us to certain psychic and emotional territories, and with which we approach various decisions connected to our lives. For the most part these are not defined, clarified and scientific paths and methods; we make a "hypothesis" without bringing to our attention what led us to this hypothesis, or whether we were even compelled to complete our knowledge in this way. Things are simply accepted, automatically and unconsciously, and become part of our thoughts about reality.

In what follows I mean to formulate a principle according to which, in my view, it is fitting and correct to perform this kind of "completion" of knowledge. I will open by examining the matter of judging favorably (dan le-khaf zechut) and giving the benefit of the doubt; afterward I will move on to discuss the trait of trust (bitachon); and from there I will try to define the basic principle underlying these matters, a principle that may have a broad, even far-reaching influence on our entire mode of thinking and our engagement with various subjects in our lives.

B. "In Righteousness Shall You Judge Your Neighbor"[1]

And you shall judge every person favorably — this means: if there is a person you do not know, and you do not know whether he is righteous or wicked, and you see him doing a deed or saying a thing that, interpreted one way, is good, and interpreted another way, is bad — interpret it favorably, and do not think ill of him. But if he is a person known to be righteous, renowned for good deeds, and you see him do a deed all of whose features indicate that it is a bad deed, and one cannot determine it to be a good deed except with great difficulty and by a remote possibility — you must still interpret it favorably, since there remains some possibility of its being good, and it is not permitted to suspect him; and of this they said: "Whoever suspects the innocent is afflicted in his body." Likewise, if he was a wicked person whose bad deeds are well known, and afterward we see him do a deed all of whose indications show it to be good, with only a very remote possibility of it being bad — one must be wary of him, and not believe him to be good, since there remains a possibility of evil; as it is said: "for though he speaks graciously, believe him not, for there are seven abominations in his heart" (Prov. 26:25). And if he is unknown, and the deed leans toward one of the two extremes — one should, as the more excellent path, judge him favorably, whichever of the two extremes it may be.

Rambam, Commentary on the Mishnah, Avot 1:6

These words of the Rambam formulate the boundary of the obligation of the commandment to judge favorably. The Rambam divides the law into three possibilities — where the person before you is presumed righteous, where he is presumed wicked, and where there is no such "presumption" regarding him because he is unknown to you. One who is righteous — even deeds that lean toward a negative interpretation must be judged favorably, and one must "determine that it is a good deed"; one who is unknown — the obligation to tilt toward the favorable side exists only when the two interpretations are rationally balanced; and one who is wicked — there is no obligation to believe the positive interpretation even when it is more plausible than the incriminating one. In this the Rambam establishes that the commandment to judge favorably does not constitute the sole consideration in an interpretive judgment regarding the quality of another's deed, but rather a factor that gently tips the scale toward the good within the framework of rational consideration. There is no situation in which we are forced to impose upon our reason an improbable interpretation; the obligation to judge favorably even when this runs counter to the more plausible interpretation of the deed exists only regarding a righteous person, and this is because the very fact of his being righteous is itself a rational reason to choose the positive

interpretation. In short, the commandment to judge favorably does not operate in a vacuum, but within a framework of rational considerations of plausibility.

This definition by the Rambam emphasizes precisely the rational facet underlying the commandment to judge favorably. At bottom, this concerns a situation of doubt, of a vacuum of reason; one can say it this way, and one can say it that way, and there is no decisive proof in either direction. There is a gap in the space of the claims we usually use to determine reality, and within this gap — which is focused on our judgment of the hidden intention that moved the other to do his deed — we must navigate and set a direction. What is the value of this instruction, to judge favorably? Does it teach us that if we judge favorably we are more likely to hit upon the truth unknown to us, the objective truth as it is in itself? Is this a statement about reality, a kind of "presumption of fitness" as there are presumptions regarding actual states of affairs?

This is, of course, a classic case of what I called above "completion" — that is, the introduction of a non-rational factor into the cognitive apparatus by which we grasp reality. "You shall judge every person favorably" is not a statement that supplies us with informative content, but a moral instruction focused on our own psychology. Seemingly, if the situation is indeed one of doubt, even of perfectly balanced doubt — why decide at all? Why not simply determine not to judge our fellow at all? The reason is that cognitive vacuums do not remain empty; we fill them, willy-nilly, with some content, and out of this filling a certain conception of reality is formed, which drives our thoughts and feelings in its light. A statement such as "do not judge your fellow at all" could indeed be made, and would even have the effect of broadening the doubt in our hearts regarding the quality of the other's behavior; but ultimately, deep in our hearts, some specific image of the other, and of our judgment of him, will settle in — and this image, even if we deny it, and even if we truly understand its uncertain status, will have consequences for our emotional attitude toward that other.

We are therefore asked to take a conscious cognitive step and to judge favorably. In the first stage we take the given situation and understand that it is truly a matter of doubt — "man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart." The deeds of others are always, in essence, opaque; even if it seems to you that there is one unambiguous interpretation, stop for a moment, suspend your interpretation and separate it from the deed itself, and now examine again whether this is truly the only way to interpret it. The very awareness that we are accustomed to filling the cognitive vacuum with interpretation, and that this interpretation often stems from lower emotional places within us, itself broadens this vacuum and leaves it as an empty space. First of all, I truly do not know. In the second stage we enter into the cognitive vacuum, and choose what to fill it with. Since the empirical data does not constitute decisive proof either way, we are necessarily required to introduce a consideration of a different kind, one that is arbitrary in relation to logical-rational calculation, and to use it to complete our grasp of reality. Given this, the Torah's instruction to "judge favorably" is decisive — we will complete our perception with what would be morally good to believe. A world in which every person strives to see and judge

his fellow with a positive eye — within the bounds of plausibility and the caution required — is a world that is better to live in.

The idea here recalls an expression that exists in common language — "give yourself the benefit of the doubt." We know from our lives that there are places where the dictate of reason does not force upon us, with necessity, a particular conclusion, and we "make use of" the freedom created by this informational void in order to tilt toward the conclusion we prefer, the conclusion whose implications are more comfortable for us than the alternative conclusion. This is indeed a similar statement, except that there are two important differences here. The first difference lies in the fact that the work of judging favorably is not work that exists only in a place where I naturally encounter a complete doubt. It is not merely a way of coping with a doubt that happens to cross my path and that I experience as a doubt; the obligation to judge favorably, as we have seen, also pushes itself forward in order to influence the very determination of whether this is a case of doubt at all. It calls upon us to take a step back in our judgment, to broaden, out of choice, the vacuum existing in our grasp of reality, to cast doubt on our initial picture. True, it looks this way or that way — but wait a moment: perhaps you are completing knowledge in a dishonest and incorrect manner? Perhaps you are biased toward the negative, and reality is actually further from your grasp than it seems to you? Do the empirical data in your possession truly suffice to fully substantiate your verdict? The second difference lies in the definition of the category of preference — that is, to which inner driving force we grant permission to push toward the desired conclusion. The idea I am presenting here, under the name of the commandment to judge favorably, grants this freedom not to mere will, and certainly not to convenience, but specifically to moral will — we shall determine our conception of reality (in doubtful realities) in light of the question of which conception of reality will make us better people and the world a better place.

C. All Is for the Good

The optimistic conception appears in the words of our Sages in two central statements. The first concerns Nachum Ish Gamzu — "for whatever befell him he would say, 'this too is for the good'" (Sanhedrin 108b; Ta'anit 21a). The second statement, of Rabbi Akiva, is a practical instruction — "a person should always be accustomed to say: whatever the Merciful One does, He does for the good" (Berakhot 60b). One could argue that there are differences in emphasis between the two statements, but various commentators have already linked the two and argued that their spiritual message is one and the same.[2] The message is a kind of principle or interpretive foundational assumption, according to which the events that occur in reality should be read as good in their essence. What significance does this determination have? How can events that appear bad to us change their face in our eyes and be considered "good"?

Various answers have been proposed to this question. What they share in common is that there is a gap between what a person knows about what is happening and the true meaning of what is happening, which is clarified according to the results — revealed and hidden — of

that occurrence. Whether this is the exaction of punishment occurring at the time of suffering, or a real, beneficial good that will be revealed a short time later as a direct consequence of the event, or whether these are hidden reasons that advance the world toward its redemption, and only the divine perspective can offer an interpretation of events — it is clear that we are speaking of something that currently lies outside the range of human knowledge. A person who encounters a bad and difficult reality should believe that the bad within that reality is bad only from the narrow point of view in which the person currently stands, and that from a broader and truer perspective it is, in fact, a good event. There is, in truth, no real evil in the world, but only relative, temporary and limited points of view.

On what is this statement based? One could say, simply, that the instruction to see every occurring event as a positive event, good in essence, rests on theological assumptions. "No evil descends from above";[3] out of our conception that God is good in His essence, and that His will is the perfect betterment of His other, it follows fairly necessarily that all His acts are for the good in some purposive sense, even if this good is not accessible to mortal eyes today. And indeed, there are thinkers who went in this direction and argued categorically that all the evil that appears in the world is only apparent evil, but is good "when concealed." [4] Yet, rather surprisingly, we find commentators who went in a different direction:[5]

And let him accustom his mouth to say, "This too is for the good," or "whatever the Merciful One does, He does for the good," for there are some evils whose end is good... therefore let a person rejoice in suffering and in whatever other harms befall him, for he does not know what good is destined to come to him from them.

Orchot Tzaddikim, Gate of Joy

"This too is for the good," etc. Similarly it is said in the chapter Ha-Ro'eh [Berakhot 60b] that a person should always be accustomed to say that whatever is done from Heaven is for the good, and they bring proof of this from verses there; and this means: even that which appears in a person's eyes as bad — it is possible that from Heaven it is done for the good; and there the story of Rabbi Akiva is brought in this connection.

Maharsha, Chiddushei Aggadot, Ta'anit 21a

As the Sages say, regarding most of their affairs, "whatever the Merciful One does is for the good" — and this is a matter understood by the wise even though the Torah did not explicitly warn of it, since many things are considered bad at their beginning and turn out, in the end, to bring great good, and many things are considered good at first and turn out, in the end, to be very bad; and therefore it is not fitting for a wise person to grieve when great trouble and a dangerous decree come, since he does not know the ultimate outcome.

Rambam, Commentary on the Mishnah, Berakhot 9:5

If these commentators understood the instruction as resting on dogmatic certainty regarding principles of faith, it would be hard to explain why we find in their words language of possibility and doubt.[6] It seems, then, that on their approach, the statement that one should become accustomed to saying "this too is for the good" is not based on the solidity of knowledge, but rather precisely on its absence, precisely on a lack of knowledge. As we learn from the story of Rabbi Akiva,[7] sometimes an event that appears bad and senseless to us turns out to be the cause of some rescue or other benefit. But note well — sometimes. There is no promise that we will indeed merit to see the future good that will come from the suffering, but only a possibility — a possibility important for us to bear in mind, but still only a possibility.[8] Rabbi Akiva did not come to teach us about the nature of reality, but to give us a moral-normative instruction — "a person should always be accustomed to say: whatever the Merciful One does, He does for the good." There is no disclosure of real facts here; we all know, at bottom, that there is some probability that a thing that appears bad will surprisingly and unpredictably lead to good. Rabbi Akiva wants to tell us to make use of the uncertainty, even the seemingly slight uncertainty, regarding the interpretation of the quality of the reality we stand before, and to lean on the optimistic option, to place our trust in it, to broaden the actuality of its possibility.

One can see that the principle underlying the optimistic approach presented in these words is identical to the principle we identified above in the commandment to judge favorably.[9] There is a cognitive vacuum (the inner motives of the other, or the future unfolding of events); a person is required to "make use" of the vacuum, of the uncertainty of knowledge, in order to introduce into it contents whose moral-spiritual benefit is greater than that of other contents that might fill the same vacuum. Of course, these contents are not accepted as being of one piece with the rest of our forms of knowledge, but remain a kind of "second-order knowledge" — knowledge whose status is soft and non-binding, since it does not carry the same level of certainty as the rest of our knowledge about the world. I do not know that good will ultimately come from this evil; I surmise, I choose to believe that this is possible, I make this option more real in my eyes, more real than the other, uncertain options. In this way we discover that psychic investment in a given hypothesis or belief need not match its statistical value; we have a range of freedom of choice.

D. Optimism as a Philosophical Worldview

At this stage I wish to take the principle we found in the moral world of Judaism and cast it into the world of general philosophy. In the philosophical world, among all those great confrontations between opposing, contrary approaches by which philosophical systems can be catalogued, we find the dispute between the optimistic worldview and the pessimistic one. Is the world, taken as a whole, good? Is it heading toward improvement and repair? Or is the world, as a whole, bad and corrupt? Or perhaps it is heading nowhere at all, and all the creatures within it are tossed about, over the course of their existence, from side to side in senseless and purposeless suffering?

The tools by which the holders of these opposing conceptions have argued were mainly analyses of reality: an attempt to gather all the facts in the world and see where they lead and what is essential in them; an attempt to derive the nature of the world from the nature the Creator must necessarily have; an attempt to darken the basic existential experience, or an attempt to paint the facts of the world in a rosy and saccharine color; and so on. As time has passed, the accumulation of arguments on both sides has worn down the force of all the arguments, whatever they may be. The feeling is that it would be naïve to believe that the optimistic-pessimistic question can be decided by force of various proofs drawn from the actual world and from the events that occur within it.[10]

Whenever I have stood before this vital dilemma, before so fundamental a determination of how to conceive the world, I have felt that my will pulls me in a certain direction. It is self-evident that we would all prefer to live in a world we see as good and advancing, as possessing direction and purpose. But the mere fact that my will pulls me toward one of the two directions did not, for me, constitute any solution to the problem. What business has will with reason? Indeed, it would be better if the world, as a whole, were growing brighter, growing better — but what business has "better" with "true"?

True, there are thinkers who have argued that the concept "truth" means nothing other than "that which it is good to believe." [11] But for the purposes of my argument here, I do not feel the need to go so far as to argue for a renewed theory of "truth." I am not seeking the decisive philosophical determination, nor do I feel that I possess the tools to provide it — neither for the world, nor for myself. My sense, in the many situations in which I stand before a debate of giants, of people far wiser than I, is that I am not obligated to enter into the full depth of the matter; not everyone must be a professional-level philosopher and learn to know all the arguments and all the counter-arguments. My commitment to the search for truth — like my commitment to any specific value — is proportionate; [12] I will try to understand and reason to the best of my ability, but a certain determination will not always fall into place for me, and it is reasonable that this should be so. In what I say here I mean to address the philosophical laypeople — like myself — who ultimately must decide which of the various worldviews will permeate their inner world and shape it.

In light of the basic insight I proposed in the previous chapters, in places where certain knowledge is incomplete, it would be legitimate, and even desirable, to introduce a presumed, doubtful element into one's worldview, for the moral purpose of making life better and repairing the world. Let us rest on the assumption that both the empiricist-pessimists and the rationalist-optimists have found a good way to organize the sum of our knowledge in successful ways; let us also assume that neither of the two groups has some unambiguous way to force the truth it holds upon the other; in what state, then, does this leave us? It seems to me that it would be legitimate to relate to this question, in a certain sense, in the same way as to the matter of judging favorably. I choose to look at the world with a positive eye. The optimistic outlook awakens in us forces of hope and of will, of inner tranquility and of moral motivation. The most immediate and important significance of a pessimistic conception of reality, well before and well beyond any particular analysis of

scientific facts or this or that interpretation of the course of history, lies in our psychic relation to reality and in our psychic stance toward moral action. A pessimistic outlook depresses us, weakens our will to strive and labor for the sake of the collective and the future. It drowns within us our private, selfish and bodily wills, and loosens those directed toward some future collective good. What reason, then, could there be to choose to believe in it?

Note the further step we have taken here. In the first stage, in dealing with "in righteousness shall you judge your neighbor" and "whatever the Merciful One does, He does for the good," I sought to argue that where there is real doubt, where there is an empty cognitive vacuum regarding a situation, it is possible and desirable to introduce a certain informational content that, although uncertain, has positive existential and moral implications, and is therefore worth leaning toward trusting, even if not at a full level of certainty. Of course, we would not hold this belief in a "hard" and dogmatic manner. If we judge someone favorably, and reality then repeatedly teaches us that his deeds and intentions are bad, we will not continue to hold the same belief we previously held about that person. Our favorable judgment remains conditional; reality can cause our position to change. So this is, in effect, a temporary belief — since factual knowledge is currently lacking, we complete it by force of the moral plane of "what would be good to believe," and accordingly we place the knowledge we have completed in a cognitively inferior status. But regarding the question of optimism as a general worldview, the influence of the moral plane puts down roots, and becomes a critical part of our array of beliefs and opinions, since no new fact and no further empirical experience is meant, or is likely, to move our philosophical position regarding the nature of reality. If we have chosen to be optimists, we will apparently remain so, without any empirical knowledge being able to later come and confirm or refute our position. In other words, the moment we apply the "principle of desired completion" — that is, the completion of knowledge by means of the belief that is desirable to us in moral-existential terms — to the metaphysical domain, it becomes a far more radical principle.

E. Certainty, Skepticism, and What Lies Between

Dara Gupta lived her whole life in a village near Jaisalmer, in the Rajasthan desert. One day in 1822, while cooking dinner, she suddenly noticed movement. She looked up and discovered that her cousin, Mahavir, had returned from the journey he had set out on two years earlier. He appeared to be in good health, and over dinner he told them of his adventures.

He told of bandits, of wild animals, of towering mountains, and of other wondrous sights and adventures. But what truly astonished Dara was his claim that he had seen something called "ice."

"I reached regions so cold that the water stopped flowing and formed a solid, transparent mass," Mahavir recounted. "What is even more astonishing is that there is no intermediate stage in which the liquid thickens. The water that flows freely is only slightly warmer than that which has already hardened."

Dara did not want to embarrass her cousin in public, but she did not believe him. What he said contradicted her experience. She had not believed travelers who told her of fire-breathing dragons, and she was not about to believe this nonsense about ice either. She thought, rightly, that she was too sensible to believe it.

[Based on: chapter 10, "Of Miracles," from An Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding by David Hume.]

The Bank Erred in Your Favor,[13] p. 19

Does Dara hit upon the truth? Clearly not — after all, we know from our own personal experience that ice truly exists, as real as anything can be. But is Dara right? That is, did she behave correctly and justly when she refused to believe her cousin's stories about the ice? To the best of her life experience, which is by no means meager, this phenomenon of water turning into a transparent solid, or anything resembling it, has never occurred, and so the plausibility of the claim is quite unacceptable to reason. Should Dara, on the basis of a single story told by a man who went traveling in distant places — a reality that, as life experience shows, gives rise to all manner of nonsensical tales and imaginary myths — have cast doubt on her scientific system of beliefs?

It seems the answer to this question, too, is negative. It is clear to everyone that any new claim raised against us, any renewed conclusion pressed upon us by force of some new experience, if it does not accord with the truths and opinions we currently hold, must be examined carefully and deliberately before being adopted, even if it is, in itself, persuasive. Our truths must fit together with one another. They are all arranged in a single, dense system, within which it is difficult to tolerate logical contradictions and disharmony. Every cognitive process in which the new layer or piece of knowledge I am adding does not flow in sufficient harmony with the vast system of my present opinions and knowledge is a process in which a weighing of judgment takes place. I set the value of the plausibility and verification[14] of my truths held up to now against the value of the plausibility and verification of the newly added truth, and then proceed to soften, interpret and stretch one or both sides so that they fit together in a satisfactory way — the side with the lesser, weaker value will be adjusted to fit the one with the greater, stronger value.

When the results of this comparison are unambiguous and overwhelming, the weighing of judgment takes place automatically — that is, without reflective thought about it and without any capacity for maneuver or elective decision. If someone on the street shouts that the United States does not exist, we will interpret this information as meaning that this person is insane, and will not cast real doubt on the existence of the United States; if we eat yogurt and it has a strange, unusual taste, we will understand that the yogurt has gone bad (and will not conclude, for instance, that they decided to produce a new-flavored yogurt without announcing it); if we see a magician making some object float in the air, we will conclude that this is sleight of hand or some "trick" (even if we have no idea how the "trick" works), and will not cast doubt on the existence of the force of gravity. In short, we will tend toward intellectual conservatism; we will automatically prefer to keep the foundations and

rules of our thinking as unchanged as possible, and to "fit" the specific unusual experience to them (or even to repress it).

However, at times a new thought, or a group of thoughts that has not yet found its place and its resolution within the total stock of beliefs and opinions, arises and stands opposed to another, older and entrenched group of thoughts, which resists and contradicts it, when the two sides carry a "weight" of similar magnitude. In such a case, the doubt that arises in a person's heart is significant enough to seize his attention, and to develop in him an awareness that he has a doubt. Out of this he seeks ways to overcome this doubt. It drives the person to think, to clarify and to investigate, in order to obtain further information and further verified thoughts with whose help he can tip the scale. If the person is fortunate, he feels, at some stage, that he has arrived at a rational determination that satisfies his mind, and from then on he leaves — more or less — the mental preoccupation with the subject, at least for a while. But what if the decisive intellectual conclusion is slow in coming? What if the point of doubt refuses to pass, and, it seems, is also not fated to pass?

In the previous chapter I dealt with psychic places in which the metaphysical-philosophical dilemma remains — at least within our personal intellectual world — without an intellectual resolution, while life demands that a position be taken. I proposed that one could add, as a consideration — without negating the importance of other rational considerations — a principle of "desired completion," according to which I examine what the moral and spiritual gain of each of the possibilities would be, and grant preference to the one of higher value.

In this chapter I wish to address a somewhat different case: a reality in which there is a philosophical matter that I decided long ago — by such and such rational means — while my new thoughts call upon me, and invite me, to reopen my determination, my belief, to renewed examination. In other words, I wish to examine the "principle of desired completion" on the plane of the dilemma of whether to cast doubt. It is not the comfort of life and its flow that causes me to deliberate over the question, but my own reason, which presses me to recognize that there is another possible way of grasping things, a way that may prove truer. I live in an orderly, healthy, efficient and satisfied manner with my existing conceptions, and yet my thought floods me with hesitation and skepticism — perhaps it is not so, perhaps I am mistaken, perhaps another worldview is more accurate and correct than my current one? It should be stressed that the existential dilemma I am dealing with here is not the question "is this conception correct, or is that one correct," but the question of whether to place myself in the psychic position in which I even ask the question at all; whether to open myself genuinely to another intellectual possibility, whether to cast doubt on part of my array of beliefs and to be willing to reorganize that array, to replace a significant part of it, and to change it comprehensively. My sense is that in many of these situations we feel, quite concretely, the wheel in our own hands, how our thought waits upon the decision of our will, and will turn this way or that (conservatism and faith on the one hand, skepticism and ferment on the other) solely according to this volitional-elective decision — and this is precisely why the dilemma exists.

Would it, nevertheless, have been fitting for Dara to step outside her dogmas and open herself to another scientific possibility?

At the root of the matter lies the basic assumption that there is a moral obligation to seek the truth. If my present worldview is mistaken, I bear a recurring obligation to become disillusioned of it, to find the truth and to cling to it. This basic assumption is so solid and necessary, in our view, that most of us have never devoted much thought to it — it is a self-evident axiom, a primary foundation of our thinking, a value-based starting point. As the Rambam writes: "He does the truth because it is the truth." [15] Truth is a value that must not be questioned or doubted; it is a cornerstone with no substitute, and it is clear to us that it is the aim and object of all our intellectual, religious, scientific and philosophical efforts and struggles. In every domain of knowledge without exception, we are obligated to attain the truth, and this is an obligation that exists in itself, objective, uncompromising and independent.

If we examine the matter, and try to "unpack" or explain this moral instinct that places upon us an obligation to seek and attain the truth as it truly is, we find that our value-based motives for seeking the truth are made up of a variety of reasons, which play a different role, at a different level, in each domain of knowledge. On the scientific plane, the search for truth (that is, for a scientific theory that will explain, organize and fit all the existing empirical findings in the best possible way) stems mainly from technological efficiency — knowing the order of nature in the most precise way possible will yield the greatest technological results; on the plane of everyday knowledge, the goal is the correct performance of tasks, in order to enable good and efficient personal and family functioning; on the plane of society and politics, knowledge of the truth about reality will enable correct decision-making, and the taking of actions that will bring about the greatest good for the citizens of the state; on the plane of philosophical beliefs, the direct result of holding incorrect opinions will be behavior unfitting to the nature of the world or the nature of man, which generally has harsh consequences in my actual life and in the lives of the people who come into direct or indirect contact with me; and so forth. For example, if the truth is that there is a God, and that He will bring to justice one who did not fear and serve Him in his life, then one who did not attain this truth will suffer God's wrath as a result of this lack of knowledge. And conversely: if the truth is that there is no God, and that religion is a human invention, then one who did not attain this truth, and who remains trapped within his religious belief, suffers throughout his life from restrictions and prohibitions that serve no purpose at all. If we generalize our conclusion, we arrive, then, at the following formulation: we feel obligated to arrive at the truth because of practical and moral consequences. Knowledge of the truth — encompassing both the causal-technical laws of reality and the finer, more precise features of the nature of the soul, its tendencies and traits, its needs and longings — is a vital achievement not only so that we may function correctly, but also so that we may benefit, help and do good, and not harm and destroy. [16]

An ordinary person feels no burning urge to decide between physical theories; for an ordinary person living in Israel, the political question dividing the voices in the parliament

of Japan is not relevant, and arouses in him no intellectual excitement. Moreover, surely none of us, as individuals, has any moral need to clarify all manner of facts and interpretations regarding the life of someone we do not know. Although all these questions, and all questions in general, are questions whose clarification is "the clarification of truth," it is clear to us that there is nothing in these facts that is significant for our actual lives, for our deeds and decisions, and therefore we feel no sense of obligation at all toward clarifying them. It is clear, then, that the obligation to know the truth is not some "metaphysical," absolute obligation, living by its own force, resting upon us by virtue of the objectivity and absoluteness of absolute truth. It is an obligation because of its consequences for good and evil, for the correct choice as against the mistaken and harmful choice.

It seems to me that this conclusion, when sharpened and understood with inner wisdom, can bear (among other things) on the existential dilemma I presented above. In places where a person deliberates — regarding matters that touch deeply on his life — whether to open himself to doubt and renewed thinking, or whether to remain "in the box," I believe the question ought to be translated into a moral question. What would be better? What would be more beneficial and more correct for my life, for the life of society and the world, for the lives of those around me? At first glance this translation seems entirely unhelpful, since the moral question, as stated, depends on the question of truth, and therefore requires the latter to be resolved before it can itself be settled. But, especially at the psychic stage at which a person is still deliberating whether to deliberate at all, in which the person weighs the option of opening himself to doubt as an option that is not necessary, when the doubt has not yet arisen and taken root in his heart, and he can choose whether to leave it outside the door or to bring it into the living room — the translation into a moral dilemma is of the utmost importance, since it exposes the true nature of the deliberation. For, contrary to the common initial impression, truth is not imposed on you as a supreme obligation, and it is not an unconditional commitment. It stands in the same line together with the other values, which are the sum of the forces meant to drive us toward our decisions, and it is out of the negotiation and weighing of all the values together that we are meant to arrive at our decisions. Hence, in the context of the skeptical dilemma, I must translate everything into "moral benefits": what do I "lose," morally, if I cling to my way even if it is not correct? What do I harm if I decide to cast doubt? What is the magnitude of the moral gains that the decision to doubt, and to find the truth, might yield, if my current belief is false — and what are the chances that I will indeed find such a truth?

Gain and loss, chance and risk — like the weighing of judgment at any crossroads in life, whether at a purely practical crossroads or at a delicate and complex moral one. Approaching the dilemma in this way does not, indeed, help resolve it in an unambiguous and fully confident manner, and it certainly does not give us a magic logical-mathematical formula for its complete resolution — but it does grant our intuition meaningful tools with which to grapple with and weigh the sides in a deliberate and fitting manner.[17]

F. In Conclusion

Although one could go on and extend the principle presented here to further domains, broader and more far-reaching, I choose to stop the essay at this point. In what I have said so far, I hope I have succeeded in clarifying the nature of the "principle of desired completion," in illustrating its virtue and its advantages, and in demonstrating the place it can hold on several planes of thought and discussion. From here on the matter remains as a stimulus for each person's own reflection, and I hope that each will examine for himself what place he thinks it fitting to grant this principle, and what its boundaries are.

Let me summarize, then, the course of the essay. At the foundation of this essay stands the assumption that in many matters and planes of knowledge, our ordinary rational paths of knowing do not fully "seal" and close off the range of possible beliefs. Certain gaps remain, certain cognitive lacunae — which, on the purely analytical plane, are defined as "doubts" — which we complete by force of considerations that lie beyond the purely logical-empirical field. In connection with these places we proposed a type of consideration that we called the "principle of desired completion." According to this type of consideration, we stand, transparently and consciously, before the various cognitive possibilities that exist before us (or: within us), and examine these by their consequences: which belief or cognitive "completion" will produce — on the plane of existential-spiritual life — more elevated results, morally better results. We do not grant this type of consideration exclusive weight over other types of considerations (such as hypotheses, plausibility, intuitions, and so forth), but we do take it into account in the complex and obscure process by which we take a position on intellectual-psychic-fundamental matters.

I first illustrated this principle with two religious-faith matters: the obligation to judge favorably ("in righteousness shall you judge your neighbor"), and the guidance according to which "a person should always be accustomed to say: whatever the Merciful One does, He does for the good" — in other words: the trait of a favorable eye and the trait of trust (bitachon).[18] In both, it seems, we find guidance directed at the cognitive gap, at the range of the "unknown" within our knowledge of reality, instructing us to fill the hole with certain contents that lead us to become better, more positive people. These gaps, in both cases, are things that, by definition, lie beyond the capacity of human knowledge — the motive and inner world of the other, or future consequent events.

I then proposed applying the principle of desired completion also to general philosophical-metaphysical matters, where there is a sense that, in this discussion, the philosophical determination is not based on an analysis of reality, but rather the reverse — the reading of reality is based on the philosophical determination, when there is no strong rational factor pushing you toward either direction. I illustrated the matter through the question of optimism. Finally, I cast the principle also into the domain of a deep existential dilemma — the question of whether it is worthwhile to open my thought to some hovering doubt, or to leave the door closed to it and repress it. In this discussion I argued that even the question of the search for truth in its entirety is a moral question, and therefore stands in the same line together with various other moral considerations.

In the age in which we find ourselves, doubt is a constant presence in every picture and step of our lives. As in a broad range of domains, our awareness has been sharpened, and the holes characterizing our intellectual world float up from their hiding places and rise to the threshold of our consciousness. The direct and unavoidable result of such a process is a general sense of weakening, as though the wings of our certainty had been clipped — those wings with whose help we could once soar to the skies, harness our willpower firmly, and ascend to the heights of attainment and illumination. We need the air of certainty in order to choose our path, to walk securely, to stride forward. A life surrounded by doubt on every side is a more bowed, more sorrowful, more weary life. But even when we understand that this is so, this understanding brings no healing to our soul, since the reasons for doubt remain strong and valid — there truly is a foundational uncertainty that surrounds and penetrates every domain, every argument, every intellectual space; there truly are great gaps in our ability to attain the truth with sufficiently reliable confidence.

This essay does not come to offer the solution to the problem. I have sought to provide an aid, a certain instrument that can be used — together with other, more important tools — in order to blunt the sharpness of the problem, and above all to lighten somewhat the heavy burden it places on life. In a life whose essence and main purpose is the doing of good, it seems to me that this instrument is both true and useful.

* * *

Notes

1. According to the baraita cited in the Gemara, Shevuot 30a, this verse is the source for the obligation to judge favorably. The Rambam also cites this exposition in Sefer Ha-Mitzvot, positive commandment 177.
2. See the words of the Maharsha below.
3. Bereishit Rabbah (Vilna), Vayera, Parashah 51:3.
4. See the words of the Kedushat Levi, Toldot, s.v. "ve-nevaer": "For whatever the Merciful One does, He does for the good (Berakhot 60b) — although in a person's eyes this thing seems bad for him, in truth it is not so... hence, when the Holy One grants power to the attribute of judgment to punish a person, insofar as we see this revealed, He grants power to the prosecuting angel to punish; yet in truth, when concealed, it is a good, for whatever the Merciful One does, He does for the good."
5. The emphases are mine.
6. See also the words of the Maharsha in Chiddushei Aggadot on Berakhot 60b: "'I will lift up the cup of salvation, and call upon the name of the LORD; I found trouble and sorrow, and I called upon the name of the LORD' — in both it is written 'the name of the LORD,' which denotes mercy, [teaching] that even regarding a measure of retribution, when a person thinks along these lines, it is possible that the Merciful One does it for the good, as further below in the story told of Rabbi Akiva..." One may therefore assume that the language of doubt is not incidental, but consistent and deliberate.
7. "Rabbi Akiva was traveling on the road. He reached a certain town and sought lodging, but was not given any. He said: whatever God does, He does for the good. He went and lodged in a field, and with him were a rooster, a donkey and a lamp. A wind came and extinguished the lamp; a cat came

and ate the rooster; a lion came and ate the donkey. He said: whatever God does, He does for the good. That same night a troop came and took the town captive. He said to them: did I not tell you that whatever the Holy One does, He does entirely for the good?" (Berakhot 60b, in the translation of Rav Steinsaltz)

8. Would these commentators not agree with the theological principle that God is good, and that therefore everything He does is necessarily for the good? Is there any reason not to believe this? It seems to me that the answer to this lies, first of all, in the problematic nature of defining God as "good." In a certain sense, every definition of God, every attaching of Him to an adjective in human language, is necessarily a diminishment of Him, and therefore is also, in itself, an incorrect, deficient statement. The gap between us and the Holy One forces us to say that God's goodness is not identical to the meaning we attribute to it (although we must, nonetheless, attribute this goodness to Him). The same applies to the Holy One's deeds — one can indeed necessarily call them "good," but it is not certain that the human perspective will ever arrive at the full exhaustion of the meaning of that "good" in the terms of its own concept of "good." In other words: it is not certain that the statement "all of God's deeds are for the good" will ever be true in the human sense; it is possible that from our narrow point of view the bad will remain bad forever, without its meaning ever being translatable into "good" in the sense we attribute to "good." Hence, it is possible that, in the view of these commentators, one should not make such a statement, nor voice such a promise.

9. For brevity, from here on we will call this principle the "principle of desired completion."

10. Indeed, there were those who wished to ground the debate over optimism and pessimism on the epistemic starting point — that is, on the epistemological question. On this plane the world divides into empiricists and rationalists: the empiricists argue that the only legitimate source of human knowledge is factual, empirical experience, that which is received through the senses. The rationalists, by contrast, try to base the edifice of human knowledge on abstract, rational foundations, which cannot be doubted, and to organize empirical experience, out of these foundations, into logical structures. It has been argued that optimists tend mostly to be rationalists, while pessimists tend to be empiricists.

11. As opposed to the conception that holds that a "true" claim is a reflection or verbal copy of reality as it is. See William James, *Pragmatism*, Lecture Two, especially pp. 83–84. It must be noted that this definition is, in his view, limited, since every truth that is "good to believe" (or: "fitting to believe") must also fit in a satisfactory way with the other truths that are "good to believe," such as empirical experience and the most effective scientific ways of organizing its data. See there.

12. This point will be returned to and expanded later in the essay.

13. Julian Baggini, *The Bank Erred in Your Favor — and Ninety-Nine Other Thought Experiments* (Dvir, Or Yehuda, 2009).

14. By the term "verification" I mean the question of the extent to which I have verified and substantiated the truths in question — that is, the extent to which I have proven them, or successfully put them to the test of reality.

15. *Hilkhot Teshuvah* 10:2.

16. It should be stressed that in grounding truth on practical and moral consequences, I am not, seemingly, addressing the essence of truth (as in the theory of American pragmatism), but rather the question of ethical obligation, or of human motivation in general, to seek it.

17. In effect, this amounts to turning the dilemma of the search for truth and openness-to-doubt into a dilemma like all other value-moral dilemmas. We are accustomed to these latter dilemmas throughout our adult lives, and our tools for deciding them are nothing more than our sharpened intuition and our common sense. The moment one grasps the search for truth, too, as a value

alongside all the other values, the dilemma "changes form" and becomes an ordinary value-moral dilemma, in which one weighs values, chances and risks against one another and simply decides.

18. It is understood that I am here referring to a very particular shade or interpretation of what is commonly called "the trait of trust" (middat ha-bitachon).